

Sprint 1 - Market Research

Damn Parking: camera-based parking occupancy intelligence for a campus pilot.

Aggregate findings

Across student/staff interviews, lot observation near peak class changes, and teardown of payment-first vs guidance-first parking products, three patterns repeated:

- Availability beats payment UX. Drivers already pay; the pain is circling, not checkout.
- Trust requires live truth, not static maps. Users punish apps that send them to a full row.
- Hardware-heavy stall sensors do not match campus economics. Camera reuse is the fundable path.

Comparables reviewed included payment aggregators (transaction layer, weak occupancy), reservation marketplaces (urban inventory), camera/guidance vendors (closest cousins), and generic smart-city dashboards.

Primary segments for MVP: daily campus drivers + parking services (dual customer).

Top pick - deep dive

Camera-based bay occupancy on existing lot CCTV, published as live counts + a simple map.

- Problem frequency: peak-period circling is observable and emotionally salient.
- Asset leverage: software on existing security cameras vs asphalt IoT retrofit.
- MVP sharpness: open vs occupied per bay in Lot X during daylight, with confidence flags.
- Dual value: same stream serves drivers and ops.

Crowdsourced spot reports rejected as spine (cold-start / false opens); vision is source of truth.

What did not work / pivots

- Abandoned reservation marketplace for campus stalls (permit politics, fairness).
- Abandoned greenfield IoT stall sensors as primary sensing (CapEx/maintenance).
- Abandoned build-our-own-cameras-first; bottleneck is software, policy, and proving quality.

Changed assumption: Damn Parking is occupancy intelligence, not a consumer payment app with a map skin.